A COMPANION STUDY · PRIVATE REVELATION

The Divine Mercy Devotion: Why the Holy See Forbade It, and Why Not to Pray It

The Holy Office's judgment of 1958–1959, the reversal of 1978, and what the *Diary* itself says. Every quotation is given with its source; where the defenders have a reply, the reply is stated.

Before the Council · After the Council · The contradiction · Condemnation · Caution

Summary

The “Divine Mercy” devotion is the image of the Merciful Jesus with its red and pale rays, the Feast of Mercy on the Sunday after Easter, the Chaplet, the Novena and the Hour of Mercy at three o’clock. All of it comes from the private revelations recorded by Sr Maria Faustina Kowalska (1905–1938) in her *Diary*. None of it has any other source.

This page argues that a Catholic should not pray it or spread it, for four reasons:

1. **The Holy See judged it before the Council.** In November 1958 the Holy Office ruled that Sr Faustina’s revelations were *not* supernatural (*constare de non supernaturalitate*), refused the feast, and ordered the images removed. On 6 March 1959 it published a prohibition on spreading the devotion “in the forms proposed by Sister Faustina”.
2. **The reversal came from the conciliar authorities.** The prohibition was declared “no longer binding” in 1978. The man who had pressed the cause, Karol Wojtyła, then made it the signature devotion of his pontificate. The reversal gives no doctrinal reasons, and the “bad translation” story told to explain it is not in the document and is contradicted by the Polish record.
3. **The message itself gives grounds for suspicion.** It promises total remission of sin and punishment for one day’s Communion, more than any plenary indulgence. Its promises read as unconditional and so invite presumption. It sets the visionary at the centre, and it contains statements hard to square with doctrine.
4. **Nothing is lost by declining it.** No Catholic is ever bound to accept a private revelation. Everything true in the devotion, trust in God’s mercy and the Blood and Water from the pierced Heart, the Church already gives through her own approved devotions.

Every quotation is given with its source so that it can be checked. Where the defenders have a reply, the reply is stated, and each point is graded for strength.

1. What is being claimed, and what is not

What is not claimed.

- It is not claimed that trust in God's mercy is wrong. Trust in mercy is Catholic doctrine. What is in question is one particular devotion, with its own image, feast, prayers and promises, resting on one nun's visions.
- It is not claimed that Sr Faustina was insincere or wicked. A soul can be pious and still be deceived about the source of what she sees and hears. The Church judges revelations by their content and fruits, not by the visionary's good intentions.
- It is not claimed that every sentence of the *Diary* is heretical, or that the words of the Chaplet are heretical. Several traditionalist critics, including the SSPX's Fr Peter Scott, call the Chaplet's prayers orthodox (§4.6).
- It is not claimed that people who prayed it in good faith sinned.

What is claimed. The devotion "in the forms proposed by Sister Faustina" was examined by the Holy See before the Council, judged not supernatural, and forbidden to be spread. That judgment was set aside only by the authorities of the conciliar church. A Catholic who holds that those authorities do not possess the Church's authority must treat the 1958–1959 judgment as the last word of the Holy See. A Catholic who does not hold that position is still free to decline a private revelation, and has serious reasons to do so in this case.

> **Benedict XIV**, *De servorum Dei beatificatione*, quoted in the *Catholic Encyclopedia*, "Private Revelations" (1911):
> "When the Church approves private revelations, she declares only that there is nothing in them contrary faith or good morals, and that they may be read without danger or even with profit; no obligation is thereby imposed on the faithful to believe them. Speaking of such revelations as (e.g.) those of St. Hildegard (approved in part by Eugenius III), St. Bridget (by Boniface IX), and St. Catherine of Siena (by Gregory XI) Benedict XIV says: 'It is not obligatory nor even possible to give them the assent of Catholic faith, but only of human faith, in conformity with the dictates of prudence, which presents them to us as probable and worthy of pius belief'".
>
> *Context:* This is the standard Catholic teaching on private revelation. Even a fully approved revelation receives at most "human faith", and the faithful are not obliged to believe it. ("Contrary faith" and "pius" are as printed on New Advent.)

2. What the Holy See decided, 1953–1959

Before the ban

Sr Faustina died in 1938. Her confessor, Fr Michał Sopoćko, spread the image and prayers in Poland and sought approval of the feast. The Holy See refused the feast before the main ruling. A Polish theologian sympathetic to the devotion, citing Ewa Czaczkowska's standard biography, writes:

> **K. Lijka**, "Nabożeństwo do Miłosierdzia Bożego", *Teologia Praktyczna* 17 (2016), p. 161ff:
> "W 1946 r. biskupi polscy skierowali prośbę do Stolicy Apostolskiej o zatwierdzenie święta. Dnia 14 maja 1953 r. Święte Oficjum uznało, że nie należy wprowadzać takiego święta. Ponowny zakaz wydano w dniu 19 listopada 1958 r."
> ("In 1946 the Polish bishops sent a request to the Apostolic See for approval of the feast. On 14 May 1953 the Holy Office decided that such a feast should not be introduced. A renewed prohibition was issued on 19 November 1958.")

In 1957 the Holy See asked for an inquiry into the spread of the cult. A survey was held in seventeen Polish dioceses. The editors of Cardinal Wyszyński's diary say its opinions "were divided: from negative, through neutral, to favourable" (*Pro memoria* t. 6, note 235).

19 November 1958: the plenary decision

The Holy Office met in plenary session on Wednesday 19 November 1958 and decided the case. The decree was not published; it was communicated to the Primate of Poland, Cardinal Stefan Wyszyński, by letter of 28 November 1958 (Prot. 65/52). On the same day, 28 November, Cardinal Ottaviani told Wyszyński the decision in person, and Wyszyński wrote it down that evening:

Cardinal Stefan Wyszyński, diary, 28 November 1958 (*Pro memoria* t. 5, IPN 2018, p. 352): "10.00. Kard[ynał] Ottaviani w Kongr[egacji] S[ancti] Officii. […] Kard[ynał] omawia sprawę s. Faustyny Kowalskiej. Stwierdza: 1) constare de non supernaturalitate; 2) nie wprowadzi się święta Miłos[ierdzia] Bożego w Dom[inica] in albis; 3) nie można propagować obrazu w formie proponowanej przez F[austynę] K[owalską]; 4) do roztropności ks[ięży] biskupów należy stopniowo je usuwać z kościołów; 5) ks. M[ichał] Sopoćko otrzyma admonicję." ("10.00. Cardinal Ottaviani at the Congregation of the Holy Office. […] The Cardinal discusses the matter of Sr Faustina Kowalska. He states: 1) *it is established that [the revelations] are not supernatural*; 2) a feast of Divine Mercy will not be introduced on Low Sunday [*Dominica in albis*]; 3) the image in the form proposed by F. K. may not be propagated; 4) it belongs to the prudence of the bishops to remove them gradually from the churches; 5) Fr M. Sopoćko will receive an admonition.")

Context: This is the critical edition of the Primate's private diary, published by the Polish Institute of National Remembrance. Its editors gloss the Latin of point 1 as "stwierdzenie, orzeczenie braku nadnaturalności", "a finding, a ruling, that [the revelations] are not supernatural" (note 1987). Two days later, on 30 November, Wyszyński records telling Maria Winowska of "the position of the Holy Office: *constare de non supernaturalitate*" (p. 356).

The Latin formula matters. *Non constat de supernaturalitate* ("the supernatural character is not established") leaves the question open. *Constat de non supernaturalitate* ("it is established that it is not supernatural") is the Holy See's negative verdict. Several English-language writers, critics and defenders alike, report point 1 as "not evident". The primary record has the stronger, negative formula.

Two further witnesses confirm the substance. Ewa Czaczkowska, the devotion's own biographer, summarizes the decree: it "zakwestionowało nadprzyrodzoność objawień s. Faustyny" ("called into question the supernatural character of Sr Faustina's revelations") and ordered Fr Sopoćko to "zaprzestał obrony i propagowania tych objawień i nabożeństw" ("stop defending and propagating these revelations and devotions"). In January 1959 Archbishop Józef Gawlina wrote that Wyszyński had told him a "komisja biskupów polskich zbadała tę sprawę i uznała objawienia Siostry Faustyny nie jako nadprzyrodzone" ("a commission of Polish bishops examined this matter and judged Sister Faustina's revelations not supernatural"). The consultor Gawlina names as the "mainspring" of the decree was Fr Karol Balić OFM (both quoted in Czaczkowska, *Polonia Sacra* 22 [2018] no. 3).

6 March 1959: the public Notification

The Holy Office then published a shorter and milder Notification. It names the devotion and forbids spreading it in Faustina's forms:

CONDEMNED · Holy Office, *Notificazione*, 6 March 1959 (*Acta Apostolicae Sedis* 51 [1959], p. 271):

"Si rende noto che la Suprema Sacra Congregazione del Sant'Offizio, prese in esame le asserite visioni e rivelazioni di Suor Faustina Kowalska, dell'Istituto di Nostra Signora della Misericordia, defunta nel 1938 presso Cracovia, ha stabilito quanto segue:

1. doversi proibire la diffusione delle immagini e degli scritti che presentano la devozione della Divina Misericordia *nelle forme proposte dalla medesima Suor Faustina*;

2. essere demandato alla prudenza dei Vescovi il compito di rimuovere le predette immagini, che eventualmente fossero già esposte al culto."

("It is made known that the Supreme Sacred Congregation of the Holy Office, having examined the alleged visions and revelations of Sister Faustina Kowalska, of the Institute of Our Lady of Mercy, who died in 1938 near Cracow, has determined as follows: 1. the spread of images and writings that present the devotion to the Divine Mercy *in the forms proposed by the same Sister Faustina* is to be prohibited; 2. the task of removing the said images, which may already be exposed for worship, is entrusted to the prudence of the Bishops.")

Context: The italics are in the original. The Notification is signed by the notary of the Holy Office, Hugh O'Flaherty. The volume's Latin index files it as: "Misericordia Divina. Erga Eam devotio iuxta formam a Sorore Faustina Kowalska propositam auctoritate S. S. C. S. Officii prohibetur" ("Divine Mercy. Devotion to it according to the form proposed by Sister Faustina Kowalska is prohibited by authority of the Supreme Sacred Congregation of the Holy Office"). Translation of the Italian is the author's.

The Polish Church obeyed. On 19 February 1959 the plenary conference of the Polish episcopate withdrew its 1954 approval of the Sleńdziński image of the Merciful Christ and "przyjęto do wiadomości dekret Stolicy Ap[ostolskiej] o zakazie propagowania objawień s. Faustyny" ("took note of the decree of the Apostolic See forbidding the propagation of Sr Faustina's revelations"; Wyszyński, *Pro memoria* t. 6, p. 55). Fr Sopoćko accepted the decree and the admonition (ibid., p. 34).

Who made the judgment

John XXIII was elected on 28 October 1958, three weeks before the plenary session. The Holy Office that judged the case was the one Pius XII had staffed, with Cardinal Ottaviani as pro-secretary. The case had been before it since at least 1953. The 1958–1959 judgment is the last word of the pre-conciliar Holy See on this devotion.

❗ The 1959 Notification carries no clause stating papal approval, and it is a disciplinary act, not a doctrinal definition. Defenders are right that it is not infallible. The argument does not need it to be. A Catholic owes prudent obedience to such a ruling, and the question is only whether a later authority could lawfully undo it (§3).

How strong: strong. The 1959 text is in the *Acta*, and the 1958 negative verdict is in the Primate's own diary.

3. The reversal of 1978, and the “bad translation” story

What the 1978 Notification says

> **Sacred Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith**, Notification of 15 April 1978 (*AAS* 70 [1978], p. 350; official English, vatican.va):
> “The question has arisen from different regions, especially from Poland and from those in authority, whether the prohibitions contained in the “Notification” of the Sacred Congregation of the Holy Office, published in the AAS (1959), p. 271, regarding devotion to Divine Mercy in the form proposed by Sr. Faustina Kowalska, are considered still in force. Having examined many original documents unknown in 1959, considering the circumstances that have profoundly changed, and having taken into account the opinion of many Polish Ordinaries, this Sacred Congregation declares that the prohibitions contained in the cited “Notification” are no longer binding.”
>
> *Context:* Signed by Cardinal Franjo Šeper, Prefect, and Archbishop Jérôme Hamer, Secretary, under Paul VI. The issue of the *Acta* is dated 30 June 1978, before Karol Wojtyła’s election on 16 October 1978.

The text gives three reasons: “many original documents unknown in 1959”, “circumstances that have profoundly changed”, and “the opinion of many Polish Ordinaries”. It does not:

- say the revelations are supernatural;
- withdraw the 1958 verdict *constare de non supernaturalitate*, which it does not mention;
- approve the feast;
- say anything about translations.

The request came “especially from Poland and from those in authority”. Devotional sources say that Cardinal Wojtyła asked for the revision in November 1977, having already opened the diocesan process for Sr Faustina’s beatification in Cracow (1965–1967). The 1965–67 dates are confirmed; the 1977 request rests on devotional and journalistic sources only.

The "bad translation" story

The account now usually given is that the Holy Office was misled by a faulty Italian translation of the *Diary*, and that the ban was lifted once the translation was corrected. Catholic Answers: "Because of faulty translations from the original Polish, St. Faustina Kowalska's writings were considered doctrinally suspect… Once the translations were corrected, the ban was lifted." The Marians of the Immaculate Conception, who promote the devotion, say the same.

The evidence does not support it.

1. **The 1978 document does not say it.** "Original documents unknown in 1959" is not "a corrected translation". The translation reading is a gloss, first found in a Polish article of 1982.
2. **The 1958 verdict was not a matter of translation.** According to Archbishop Gawlina, Wyszyński said a commission of Polish bishops, who could read the Polish, had examined the case and judged the revelations not supernatural, and Gawlina thought the Holy Office "perhaps" based its ruling on their study (§2). The editors of Wyszyński's diary write that "in the 1950s the negative opinions of theologians on the *Diary* prevailed".
3. **Sopoćko's own circle did not believe it.** A 1959 letter in the Sopoćko–Winowska correspondence, which Czaczkowska quotes and attributes in her text to Sopoćko (her footnote labels it Winowska's letter to Sopoćko of 17 March 1959), says: "dekret Św. Oficjum w sprawie Mił[osierdzia] Boż[ego] nie ulegnie zmianie, dopóki żyją ci, którzy go wydali, choćby nawet rewizja tłumaczenia Dzienniczka […] spowodowała poprawienie błędów" ("the decree of the Holy Office on Divine Mercy will not be changed while those who issued it are alive, even if a revision of the translation of the *Diary* led to the correction of its errors").
4. **The devotion's own Polish historians give doctrinal reasons.** A Polish diocesan weekly, summarizing Czaczkowska's biography, writes that "the Holy Office's main objection was that Faustina's revelations attributed to the cult of the image of the Merciful Jesus, and also to the feast of Divine Mercy and the recitation of the chaplet, an unlimited power acting of itself" ("nieograniczona moc działająca sama w sobie"; R. Jurowicz, *Opiekun*, 25 April 2022). That objection concerns the promises themselves, examined in §4.2, not a mistranslated sentence.

The American journalist John Allen, no traditionalist, put it plainly in 2002: "Officially, the 20-year ban is now attributed to misunderstandings created by a faulty Italian translation of the *Diary*, but in fact there were serious theological reservations – Faustina's claim that Jesus had promised a complete remission of sin for certain devotional acts that only the sacraments can offer, for example, or what Vatican evaluators felt to be an excessive focus on Faustina herself" (*National Catholic Reporter*, 30 August 2002).

❗ Do not repeat the common claim that Pius XII put the *Diary* on the Index. No such decree has been found; the *Diary* was not even published until much later, and the 1958 decision came after Pius XII's death. Do not say John Paul II lifted the ban either: it was lifted under Paul VI.

How strong: strong against the translation story. On the authority of the 1978 act itself, the argument depends on one's judgment of the post-conciliar authorities, which is the subject of the main thesis.

4. What the message itself says

The prohibition alone would settle the question for a Catholic who holds that the 1978 authority was not the Church's. The content of the *Diary* shows that the pre-conciliar Holy Office had good reasons. All quotations are from the Marian Press English edition, *Diary of Saint Maria Faustina Kowalska: Divine Mercy in My Soul* (3rd ed., 2005), cited by paragraph number. Words attributed to Jesus are printed in bold in that edition; here they are given as plain quotation.

4.1 A feast that wipes out all sin and all punishment

> ***Diary* §699:** "I desire that the Feast of Mercy be a refuge and shelter for all souls, and especially for poor sinners. On that day the very depths of My tender mercy are open. I pour out a whole ocean of graces upon those souls who approach the Fount of My Mercy. The soul that will go to Confession and receive Holy Communion shall obtain complete forgiveness of sins and punishment. […] It is My desire that it be solemnly celebrated on the first Sunday after Easter. Mankind will not have peace until it turns to the Fount of My Mercy."

The same promise appears at §300 ("complete remission of sins and punishment") and §1109 ("a complete pardon"). At §965 the feast is called "the last hope of salvation": "If they will not adore My mercy, they will perish for all eternity." The edition's own editors felt obliged to soften that one in an endnote: "Many souls have attained heroic sanctity, and so were saved, never having celebrated the Feast of Divine Mercy" (endnote 255).

The promise goes beyond anything the Church grants. A plenary indulgence remits temporal punishment only, and only to one wholly detached from sin. The devotion's chief theologian, Fr Ignacy Różycki, whose study the Marians use, says so himself:

> **Fr Ignacy Różycki**, lecture of 1981, quoted in *Understanding Divine Mercy Sunday* (Marian Press, 2003):
> "The most exceptional grace promised by Jesus for the Feast of the Divine Mercy is something considerably greater than a plenary indulgence. The latter consists only of the remission of temporal punishments for committed sins, but is never the remission of sins itself. The exceptional grace of [the Communion on] Divine Mercy Sunday is also greater than the graces of the other sacraments, with the exception of the Sacrament of Baptism, for the remission of all sins and punishment is found only in the sacramental grace of Baptism. In the promises cited, Christ tied the remission of all sins and punishment to the reception of Holy Communion on the Feast of Divine Mercy. In other words, in this regard, He raised it to the rank of a "second Baptism.""

The same booklet admits that what makes the feast "so extraordinary" is "uniquely, the *lesser requirement* for receiving them: the reception of Holy Communion by a heart filled only with trust in Divine Mercy. This "trust," it might be said, is not yet an act of perfect love of God, not yet perfect contrition."

So a private revelation, judged not supernatural by the Holy Office, attaches to one day of the calendar a grace its own promoters rank with Baptism, for a lesser disposition than perfect contrition. The Church's traditional language of a "second baptism" belongs to religious profession, and St Thomas grounds it in a total self-offering that "surpasses all manner of satisfaction" (*Summa* II-II q.189 a.3 ad 3), not in a lighter requirement.

Even the conciliar Holy See did not grant what the *Diary* promises. When the Apostolic Penitentiary attached a plenary indulgence to Divine Mercy Sunday in 2002, it added the traditional condition the *Diary* omits:

> **Apostolic Penitentiary**, decree of 29 June 2002 (*AAS* 94 [2002], pp. 634–636):
> "Plenaria Indulgentia conceditur, suetis sub condicionibus […] christifideli, qui, die Dominica II Paschae seu de Divina Misericordia, […] **animo quidem omnino elongato ab affectu erga quodcumque peccatum, etiam veniale**, pium exercitium in honorem Divinae Misericordiae participaverit…"
> ("A plenary indulgence is granted, under the usual conditions […] to the faithful who, on the Second Sunday of Easter or Divine Mercy Sunday, […] **with a spirit completely detached from affection for any sin, even venial**, take part in a pious exercise in honour of the Divine Mercy…")

> **Objection:** The promise is not an indulgence but a grace of the sacraments, received with the right dispositions. Adult Baptism does not require detachment from venial sin either, and an act of perfect contrition already obtains complete remission (R. Stackpole, Marian Fathers, 2010).

> **Answer:** That reply concedes the point. The grace is ranked with Baptism and perfect contrition, yet attached to a "lesser requirement" than either, on a single feast day, by a private revelation. No promise of the Sacred Heart remits all temporal punishment for one day's Communion. John Allen names this very promise among the "serious theological reservations" behind the ban (§3).

How strong: strong. The text is plain, and the promoters' own theologian confirms how far it goes.

4.2 Promises that invite presumption

The *Diary* attaches salvation, or something close to it, to the image, the Chaplet and the novena:

> ***Diary* §48:** "I promise that the soul that will venerate this image will not perish. I also promise victory over [its] enemies already here on earth, especially at the hour of death. I Myself will defend it as My own glory."

> ***Diary* §687:** "Whoever will recite it will receive great mercy at the hour of death. Priests will recommend it to sinners as their last hope of salvation. Even if there were a sinner most hardened, if he were to recite this chaplet only once, he would receive grace from My infinite mercy."

> ***Diary* §1224** (the novena, seventh day, on souls who venerate the mercy): "These souls will shine with a special brightness in the next life. Not one of them will go into the fire of hell. I shall particularly defend each one of them at the hour of death."

> ***Diary* §1146:** "Let the greatest sinners place their trust in My mercy. They have the right before others to trust in the abyss of My mercy. […] I cannot punish even the greatest sinner if he makes an appeal to My compassion, but on the contrary, I justify him in My unfathomable and inscrutable mercy."

Compare §723, "The greater the sinner, the greater the right he has to My mercy", and §1275, "I am more generous toward sinners than toward the just." At §1572, at three o'clock "you can obtain everything for yourself and for others for the asking".

St Thomas defines the sin against hope that these words invite:

> **St Thomas Aquinas**, *Summa Theologiae* II-II q.21 a.1 and a.4:
> "there may be presumption through immoderation, in the fact that a man tends to some good as though it were possible by the power and mercy of God, whereas it is not possible, for instance, if a man hope to obtain pardon without repenting, or glory without merits. This presumption is, properly, the sin against the Holy Ghost". […] "The other presumption is an inordinate trust in the Divine mercy or power, consisting in the hope of obtaining glory without merits, or pardon without repentance."

The objection is not that God cannot be generous. It is that a devotion which teaches sinners they have a "right" to mercy "before others", and that God "cannot punish" whoever appeals to it, trains souls in exactly the "inordinate trust in the Divine mercy" that St Thomas condemns. This is the "unlimited power acting of itself" which, by the Polish account, was the Holy Office's main objection (§3).

> **Objection:** The *Diary* also teaches works and reparation: "even the strongest faith is of no avail without works" (§742); the Chaplet obtains everything "if what you ask for is compatible with My will" (§1731). The promises should be read as the Gospel's promises to prayer are read, with faith and contrition presupposed. The Sacred Heart's "Great Promise" of final perseverance for nine First Fridays is just as sweeping.

> **Answer:** Such qualifications appear elsewhere in the *Diary*, which is a large book, but they are not in the promises the devotion actually circulates: the image card, the Chaplet leaflet and the Divine Mercy Sunday pamphlet. A message that needs its own endnotes and its promoters' commentaries to keep it from teaching presumption is a message the Church had reason to forbid. The Sacred Heart devotion was approved in substance by the popes (Pius XII, *Haurietis Aquas*, 1956) and is centred on reparation; it was not judged non-supernatural by the Holy Office.

How strong: moderate to strong. Each text can be read in an orthodox sense by a theologian, but the devotion presents them to ordinary faithful without the qualifications.

4.3 The visionary at the centre

True mystics are marked by humility, and the saints' revelations usually turn attention away from themselves. The *Diary* repeatedly places Sr Faustina at the centre of God's dealings with the world:

- §1193: "I bestow many graces only because of you. I also withhold My punishments only because of you. You restrain Me, and I cannot vindicate the claims of My justice. You bind My hands with your love."
- §431: "For your sake I will withhold the hand which punishes; for your sake I bless the earth." The same pattern recurs at §39, §719, §980 and §1078 ("Host, dear to My Heart, for your sake I bless the earth").
- §1061: "Beloved pearl of My Heart, I see your love so pure, purer than that of the angels".

- §587: “My daughter, if you wish, I will this instant create a new world, more beautiful than this one, and you will live there for the rest of your life.” … “With no other soul do I unite Myself as closely and in such a way as I do with you”.
- §588: “Know, My daughter, that one glance of yours directed at someone else would wound Me more than many sins committed by another person.”
- §955: “Host pleasing to My Father, know, My daughter, that the entire Holy Trinity finds Its special delight in you”. §238: “My daughter, your heart is My heaven.”
- §1650: “Don’t cry. You are that saint.”
- §1605: “Your thoughts are united to My thoughts, so write whatever comes to your mind. You are the secretary of My mercy. I have chosen you for that office in this life and the next life. That is how I want it to be in spite of all the opposition they will give you.”

In her own voice she writes that she glorifies God “as no soul has ever glorified Him before” (§836), and that “I would not want to change places even with a Seraph, as regards the interior knowledge of God which He Himself has given me. The intimate knowledge I have of the Lord is such as no creature can comprehend” (§1049).

Two things stand out. Union “as with no other soul” leaves no room even for the Mother of God. And §1605 approves in advance “whatever comes to your mind”, while predicting “the opposition” it will meet, so that any later ecclesiastical judgment against the writings is already discounted.

> **Objection:** Mystics such as St Gertrude and St Catherine of Siena use similar language of intimacy. “With no other soul” means no other soul on earth at that time (R. Stackpole and C. Sparks, 2021).

> **Answer:** The limitation “on earth at this time” is the defender’s addition; the text has no such limit. The Gertrude and Catherine parallels are to expressions of love, not to God being “restrained” and having His hands “bound” by one creature so that He “cannot vindicate the claims of [His] justice”. Allen reports that “an excessive focus on Faustina herself” was among the Vatican evaluators’ concerns.

How strong: strong as a pattern. Any one sentence can be explained; the accumulation is the point.

4.4 Statements hard to square with doctrine

- **The wounds of the risen Christ “heal” now.** §1218, the novena’s fifth day, on “heretics and schismatics”: “During My bitter Passion they tore at My Body and Heart; that is, My Church. As they return to unity with the Church, My wounds heal, and in this way they alleviate My Passion.” Christ risen “dieth now no more, death shall no more have dominion over him” (Romans 6:9). His glorified wounds do not heal, and His Passion cannot now be alleviated. The defender’s reply is that Christ suffers in His members (Acts 9:4, “why persecutest thou me?”). But the text speaks of “My bitter Passion” and “My wounds”, not of the Church’s sufferings.

- **God "cannot punish".** §1146 (above): "I cannot punish even the greatest sinner if he makes an appeal to My compassion". The Church teaches that God punishes the impenitent; an appeal to compassion without repentance does not bind Him.
- **Sinners preferred to the just.** §1275: "I am more generous toward sinners than toward the just." §1146: sinners "have the right before others". The Gospel's joy over the repentant sinner (Luke 15:7) is not a greater generosity toward sinners as such.
- **A new reason for the agony in the garden.** §1228, the novena's ninth day, says of lukewarm souls: "They were the reason I cried out: "Father, take this cup away from Me, if it be Your will.""

How strong: moderate. §1218 is the hardest for defenders. The others admit a benign reading but show careless theology in a text presented as the words of Christ.

4.5 A prophecy that failed, and a diary partly rewritten

On 29 January 1935 Sr Faustina saw the Pope (Pius XI) at Mass and "knew by interior knowledge that the Holy Father was considering this matter, which will soon come to pass in accordance with the desires of Jesus" (§368). The feast was refused by the Holy Office in 1953 and 1958, and was not instituted until 2000. Defenders answer that 2000 fulfilled it; "soon" must then stretch to sixty-five years and two refusals by the Holy See.

The *Diary* itself is not a straightforward record. The editors' endnote 42 quotes Fr Sopoćko: "When I was in the Holy Land for a few weeks, she was persuaded by a supposed angel to burn the diary. As penance, I told her to reconstruct the part destroyed. But in the meantime new experiences came, and she wrote down new and old things alternately. Hence the lack of chronological order in the diary." So by her confessor's account, part of the text was rewritten from memory after an apparition he judged false. Faustina herself never narrates the burning in the *Diary*.

How strong: moderate for §368; the burned diary is a point about reliability, not a proof.

4.6 The Chaplet's "Divinity"

> ***Diary* §476:** "Eternal Father, I offer You the Body and Blood, Soul and Divinity of Your dearly beloved Son, Our Lord Jesus Christ, in atonement for our sins and those of the whole world." […] "For the sake of His sorrowful Passion have mercy on us and on the whole world."

Some Polish theologians object to offering the Divinity to the Father. Fr Wincenty Granat, a mainstream dogmatic theologian, wrote in 1970 that "the Divinity of the Son is the same as that of God the Father, and therefore cannot be offered to the Eternal Father", and that "it is in the human nature that the Savior is the propitiation for our sins" (*Ewangelia miłosierdzia*, pp. 404–408).

❗ This is the weakest argument and should not lead. Defenders answer that "Divinity" here means the divine Person, not the divine nature, and they point to the Fatima angel's prayer, which offers "the Most Precious Body, Blood, Soul and Divinity of Jesus Christ" to the Most Holy Trinity. Fr Peter Scott of the SSPX, a critic of the devotion, says that "the prayers themselves of the chaplet of Divine Mercy are orthodox". The case against the devotion does not rest on the Chaplet's words. It rests on the judgment of the Holy See and on the promises attached to the prayers.

How strong: weak to contested.

4.7 A second Sacred Heart

The image shows rays issuing from Christ's breast, but no heart. Fr Scott: "The image has no heart. It is a Sacred Heart without a heart, without reparation, without the price of our sins being clearly evident." Sopoćko himself is reported to have said that the 1958 decree was partly caused by fear that the new cult would hinder the cult of the Sacred Heart ("ponoć", "reportedly"; Czaczkowska 2018).

The Church had already legislated against exactly this. Pius XI, through the Holy Office, deplored new devotions that imitate established ones:

> **Holy Office**, decree *De novis cultus seu devotionis formis non introducendis*, 26 May 1937, approved by Pius XI (*AAS* 29 [1937], pp. 304–305):
> "neminem iam latet novas huiusmodi cultus et devotionis formas, nonnunquam ridiculas, plerumque aliarum similium iam legitime statutarum inutilem imitationem vel etiam contaminationem, his potissimum postremis temporibus, pluribus in locis, acatholicis maxime mirantibus acriterque obtrectantibus, in die multiplicari atque inter fideles latius propagari."
> ("It is known to all that new forms of worship and devotion of this kind, often enough ridiculous, usually useless imitations or corruptions of similar ones which are already legitimately established, are in many places, especially in these recent days, being daily multiplied and propagated among the faithful, giving occasion to great astonishment and to bitter aspersion on the part of non-Catholics." Translation from "new forms" onward as given by the CMRI; the opening words are the author's.)
>
> *Context:* The decree was issued "de expresso mandato" of Pius XI, who "approved and confirmed" it in audience on 20 May 1937. It renews the decree of Pius IX of 1875 against writers who promote "unaccustomed titles of worship" under the appearance of piety.

> **Objection:** Mercy and the Sacred Heart are "two sides of the same coin… Because Jesus has only one Heart!" (Stackpole, 2010).

> **Answer:** Exactly so. The Church already had the devotion to the Sacred Heart, approved, indulgenced and centred on love, mercy and reparation. A second devotion to the same mercy, with a new image without the Heart, a new feast and new promises, is what the 1937 decree calls a useless imitation.

How strong: moderate. It is a prudential argument, but it is the Holy See's own stated principle.

5. The devotion of the conciliar church

After 1978 the devotion did not merely return; it became the emblem of the new pontificate.

DATE	EVENT
1965–1967	Diocesan process for Sr Faustina in Cracow, opened by Cardinal Wojtyła's delegate and closed by Wojtyła himself
15 Apr 1978	Prohibitions of 1959 declared "no longer binding" (under Paul VI)
30 Nov 1980	John Paul II, *Dives in Misericordia*. It does not name Faustina, but he later tied the two together
18 Apr 1993	Beatification of Sr Faustina, on Low Sunday
7 Jun 1997	John Paul II at Łagiewniki: the message of mercy "was also my personal experience, which I took with me to the See of Peter and which in a sense forms the image of this Pontificate"
30 Apr 2000	Canonization; Low Sunday renamed "Divine Mercy Sunday" for the whole Church
5 May 2000	Congregation for Divine Worship, decree *Misericors et miserator*, adds the title to the Missal
29 Jun 2002	Plenary indulgence for Divine Mercy Sunday
2 Apr 2005	John Paul II dies on the vigil of Divine Mercy Sunday
1 May 2011	His beatification, on Divine Mercy Sunday
27 Apr 2014	His canonization, on Divine Mercy Sunday
18 May 2020	Sr Faustina inscribed in the General Roman Calendar (5 October)

The decision of 1958 and the act of 2000 can be set side by side:

HOLY OFFICE, 1958, as told to Cardinal Wyszyński by Cardinal Ottaviani, 28 November 1958 (*Pro memoria* t. 5, p. 352):
"2) nie wprowadzi się święta Miłos[ierdzia] Bożego w Dom[inica] in albis"
("2) a feast of Divine Mercy will not be introduced on Low Sunday [*Dominica in albis*]")

JOHN PAUL II, homily at the canonization of Sr Faustina, 30 April 2000 (*AAS* 92 [2000], p. 672):
"It is important then that we accept the whole message that comes to us from the word of God on this Second Sunday of Easter, which from now on throughout the Church will be called "Divine Mercy Sunday"."

The contradiction. The pre-conciliar Holy Office refused a Divine Mercy feast on precisely this Sunday, after examining the revelations that asked for it, and judged those revelations not supernatural. The conciliar authority gave the whole Church precisely that feast, on precisely that Sunday, on the basis of the same revelations. The ancient octave day of Easter, *Dominica in albis*, now carries the name a private revelation asked for.

The traditionalist critics' point is that this is no accident. The Novus Ordo Watch site calls the devotion "almost a purported *"heavenly" endorsement* of John Paul II and his teachings". Fr Scott connects it with the "Paschal Mystery theology" of *Dives in Misericordia*, which in his judgment "pushed aside all consideration of the gravity of sin and the need for penance".

Be fair to *Dives in Misericordia*: §14 does say that "reparation for evil and scandal, compensation for injury, and satisfaction for insult are conditions for forgiveness", and §7 speaks of the sins of man "compensated for" by the sacrifice of the Man-God. The argument here is about the devotion, not a claim that the encyclical denies justice.

6. Objections and answers

“The ban was lifted in 1978.”

> **Objection:** Whatever the Holy Office decided in 1959, the same Congregation lawfully lifted it in 1978, and a Catholic follows the Church’s current discipline.

> **Answer:** For a Catholic who holds that the post-conciliar claimants do not possess the Church’s authority, the 1978 act has no force, and the 1958–1959 judgment is the last word of the Holy See. For one who does not hold this, the 1978 act still only declares the prohibitions “no longer binding”. It does not say the revelations are supernatural, and it never mentions the 1958 verdict that they are not. Lifting a prohibition is not an approval, and no approval could oblige anyone to believe a private revelation (Benedict XIV, §1).

“It was all a mistranslation.”

> **Objection:** The Holy Office read a corrupt Italian translation; once the real text was available, the problem disappeared.

> **Answer:** The 1978 document does not say so (§3). Before the 1958 verdict, a commission of Polish bishops, reading the Polish, had already judged the revelations not supernatural. A 1959 letter from Fr Sopoćko’s own circle expected the decree to stand even if the translation were corrected. And the problems shown in §4 are in the authorized English translation of the Polish original, published by the devotion’s own promoters.

“Sister Faustina is a canonized saint.”

> **Objection:** The Church canonized her in 2000, and canonizations are infallible.

> **Answer:** The sedevacantist answer is that a canonization by one who does not hold the papacy is not an act of the Church. Even on the other view, a canonization declares that a person is in heaven and practised heroic virtue. It does not raise her private revelations to the level of faith, which no act of the Church can do (Benedict XIV). Many canonized saints recorded visions that the Church never adopted. The SSPX, which does not hold the sedevacantist position, has itself published “serious reasons” to doubt the canonizations made under the 1983 procedures.

“People receive real graces through it.”

> **Objection:** Countless conversions and consolations have come through the Chaplet and the image.

> **Answer:** God answers sincere prayer, whatever form it takes. Graces received in prayer prove God’s goodness, not the supernatural origin of a particular revelation. Msgr Patrick Perez: “Certainly the graces are always from Heaven. But the devotion may not be.”

“The Sacred Heart promises are just as extravagant.”

> **Objection:** The Great Promise of the nine First Fridays promises final repentance, and the Church tolerates it. Why single out Divine Mercy?

> **Answer:** Because the Holy See singled it out. The Sacred Heart devotion was approved, extended to the whole Church and praised in encyclicals; the Divine Mercy revelations were judged not supernatural and the devotion forbidden. And no Sacred Heart promise remits all sins and all punishment for a single Communion on a single day.

“The prayers are orthodox. What harm is there in saying them?”

> **Objection:** Even if the visions are doubtful, “Jesus, I trust in You” and “For the sake of His sorrowful Passion, have mercy on us” are good prayers.

> **Answer:** The words are not the devotion. To say the Chaplet at three o’clock, keep the novena and venerate the image is to practise the devotion “in the forms proposed by Sister Faustina”, the very thing the Holy See forbade to be spread, and to rely on promises from revelations it judged not supernatural. Anyone who wants to say “Jesus, I trust in You” can say it without the image, the feast and the promises. The Church already gives the same truths in approved forms.

“The Fatima angel used the same words.”

> **Objection:** The angel at Fatima taught the children to offer “the Most Precious Body, Blood, Soul and Divinity of Jesus Christ”.

> **Answer:** That answers only the objection to the Chaplet’s wording (§4.6), which this page does not rely on. The angel’s prayer is addressed to the Most Holy Trinity and is known from Sr Lucia’s later memoirs. In any case the Fatima prayer carries no promise of total remission, no feast, and no Holy Office condemnation.

7. Conclusion: why not to pray it

1. **The Holy See judged it.** In 1958 the Holy Office found it "established that [the revelations] are not supernatural", refused the feast on Low Sunday, and ordered the images removed. In 1959 it forbade spreading the devotion in Sr Faustina's forms. That is the last judgment of the pre-conciliar Holy See.
2. **The reversal is no answer.** It came from the authorities of the conciliar church, gave no doctrinal reasons, and never withdrew the verdict on supernaturality. The translation story invented to explain it does not survive the Polish record.
3. **The content justifies the judgment.** A feast promising more than a plenary indulgence, ranked by its own theologian with Baptism, for a "lesser requirement"; promises that teach sinners they have a "right" to mercy and that God "cannot punish"; a visionary who "binds [God's] hands"; a prophecy that did not come to pass.
4. **It became the banner of the new religion.** It was revived by Karol Wojtyła, made the image of his pontificate, imposed on the ancient octave of Easter, and used to frame his own death, beatification and canonization.
5. **Nothing is lost.** No Catholic is bound to accept any private revelation. Everything true in the devotion the Church already teaches and provides.

What to pray instead. The devotion to the Sacred Heart of Jesus, with the First Fridays and the Act of Reparation. The Holy Rosary. The Stations of the Cross, especially on Fridays and at the hour of Our Lord's death. Frequent confession with true contrition, and an act of perfect contrition each night. On Low Sunday, the Mass of *Dominica in albis* as the Church has always said it: *Quasi modo geniti infantes*, "as newborn babes, desire the rational milk without guile" (1 Peter 2:2).

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